

Paper Tray Story Setting Card Pack

Sixteen paper cards help writers build fictional story places from tray labels, mood clues, sensory details, and map edges.

Audience: Families, homeschool groups, tutors, and adult-led writing tables for writers ages 7-11.

Format: 16 printable setting cards plus adult guide tools, setting routines, take-home setting slips, and optional share prompts

Family-safe printable writing pages for adult-led, offline story practice.

\$49

Included

- 16 printable paper tray setting cards
- Adult setup guide
- Fictional setting safety notes
- Paper tray coaching moves
- Privacy and family handoff notes
- Pack reset notes
- Six adult-led setting routines
- Ten take-home setting slips
- Eight optional share prompts
- Provider-ready PDF and ZIP artifact

Setting coaching

Before the session

- Place one printed card stack, blank slips, and pencils in a shared paper tray before writers gather.
- Read the pack aloud as pretend work; every setting must stay invented and broad.
- Choose one adult caller to handle card turns, pencil supply, and calm table pacing.
- Keep extra cards face down so the active prompt feels simple and paper-only.
- Invite writers to mark slips with invented symbols only when a card needs a label.

Paper setting setup

- Set a tray label that says Pretend Setting Cards and leave space for finished slips.
- Sort cards by broad story-place type: sky, garden, tiny market, floating shelf, and invented festival.
- Pair each card with one blank slip so writers can name a fictional detail.
- Keep answer slips loose rather than bound, so the tray stays light and fictional.
- Use only paper pieces, pencils, and printed cards for this offline lane.

Story setting coaching

- Ask for sensory but invented clues: color, sound, texture, weather, and a small surprise.
- If a writer names something actual, guide them to rename it with a made-up title.
- Keep prompts broad: a moonlit pier works better than an overly narrow named spot.
- Model one sentence that links setting to mood while staying gentle and family-friendly.
- Praise clear paper choices instead of speed, ranking, or correctness.

Privacy and safety notes

- Use invented labels and pretend symbols only.
- Skip any prompt that starts to collect family routines or traceable clues.
- Do not write actual names, map clues, travel paths, or narrow real-world facts.
- Keep finished slips in the tray or send them with families; sharing stays adult-led and offline.
- Adults should rewrite any actual-world clue into an invented broad story-place before discussion.

Family handoff

- Send one selected slip with a short note inviting more pretend setting play at the family table.
- Tell adults that blanks are for made-up details, not narrow real-world facts.
- Suggest using a fresh paper tray at the next gathering to keep the activity offline and light.
- Offer the optional prompts as aloud choices, not required written reports.
- Invite families to keep or recycle slips after the story talk.

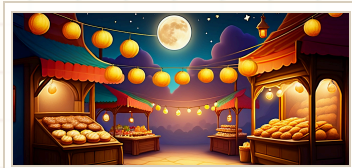
Reset

- Collect unused cards, blank slips, and pencils into the paper tray.
- Remove any slip that accidentally names a narrow real-world fact.
- Shuffle fictional setting cards so the next group starts fresh.
- Leave the tray empty of completed slips unless an adult intentionally sends them with a family.

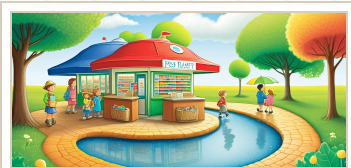
Use one paper setting card at a time. Keep every choice broad, invented, and screen-free.

Sixteen setting-card worlds

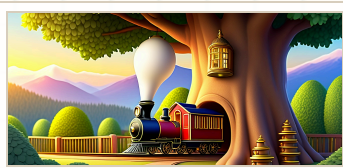
Pick a world image, then create one fictional setting from a pretend paper tray label.



AGES 6-8
Moon Muffin Market



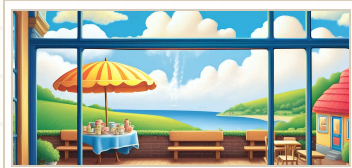
AGES 6-8
Puddle Planet Post Office



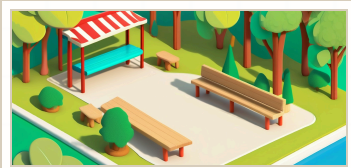
AGES 7-9
Buttonwood Library Train



AGES 7-9
Button Bakery Map Mix-Up



AGES 7-8
Teacup Town Weather Window



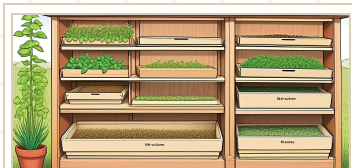
AGES 7-9
Pocket Park Notice Board



AGES 7-9
Spoon Ferry Lunchbox Harbor



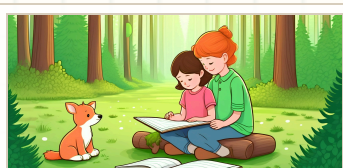
AGES 7-9
Acorn Avenue Errand Office



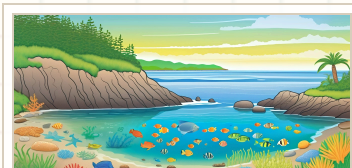
AGES 8-10
Seed Library Map Room



AGES 8-10
Rain Gauge Railway



AGES 8-10
Moss Message Observatory



AGES 8-10
Tidepool Timekeepers Lab



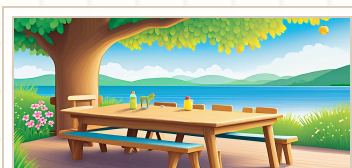
AGES 10-11
Revision River Ferry



AGES 10-11
Clue Label Tower Museum



AGES 10-11
Compass Craft Academy



AGES 10-11
Binding Day Boardwalk

Choose the paper setting rhythm

Tray Flip Setting Start Writers who need a low-pressure opening. 1. Adult places three setting cards face up in the paper tray. 2. Each writer chooses one card and adds one invented detail on a blank slip. 3. Adult reads the slips aloud and asks which detail changes the story mood. 4. Group keeps one slip under the card as the next story seed.	One Clue Many Worlds Groups practicing flexible imagination. 1. Adult names one gentle clue such as blue mist or silver moss. 2. Writers each place that clue into a different fictional setting card. 3. Adult invites each writer to add one texture or sound on paper. 4. Group compares how the same clue feels different in each made-up story-place.
Weather Mood Swap Linking setting to feeling without heavy themes. 1. Adult selects one setting card and places two blank weather slips beside it. 2. Writers invent two gentle weather choices for the same setting. 3. Adult reads both choices and asks how each changes the opening line. 4. Group circles one choice to use in a new paper story start.	Tiny Prop Big Setting Writers who like concrete details. 1. Adult places one pretend object slip beside a setting card. 2. Writers describe where the object rests using only fictional clues. 3. Adult asks what the object reveals about the wider story-place. 4. Group writes one shared sentence that names the setting and the object.
Paper Gallery Pass Quiet groups that benefit from turn-taking. 1. Adult lays four fictional setting cards in a row on the table. 2. Writers add one blank slip beside any card that gives them an idea. 3. Adult reads the new slips in card order without naming writers. 4. Group chooses one setting to carry into a short story start.	Setting Doorway Build Starting a story with a strong entrance. 1. Adult chooses a card and says the setting has an imaginary doorway. 2. Writers draw or write one invented clue found near the doorway. 3. Adult asks what the clue suggests about the setting beyond the doorway. 4. Group writes one opening sentence that steps into the fictional story-place.

Finish one story setting later

ONE PAPER PASS SENSORY DETAIL Cloud Harbor Slip Add one invented sound for Cloud Harbor: _____. A grown-up can ask what changed when the sound showed up: _____.	FAMILY TABLE PASS MOOD SETTING Velvet Hill Slip Name one gentle color that covers Velvet Hill: _____. A grown-up can ask what feeling that color gives the story: _____.
CALM PENCIL PASS SETTING CLUE Silver Moss Pier Slip Write one made-up clue found on Silver Moss Pier: _____. A grown-up can ask what the clue makes a character wonder: _____.	SHARED ALOUD PASS TEXTURE DETAIL Glass Pebble Cove Slip Add one invented texture for Glass Pebble Cove: _____. A grown-up can ask how the texture changes the next sentence: _____.
PAPER TRAY PASS MOVEMENT IN SETTING Kite Forest Clearing Slip Write what moves gently in Kite Forest Clearing: _____. A grown-up can ask where the movement leads the story: _____.	ANY CALM PAUSE WORLD DETAIL Paper Moon Market Slip Invent one quiet booth at Paper Moon Market: _____. A grown-up can ask what the booth gives to the story: _____.
ONE-CARD PASS SETTING CONTRAST Button Bridge Isle Slip Add one soft surprise near Button Bridge Isle: _____. A grown-up can ask why the surprise belongs there: _____.	PENCIL-AND-PAPER PASS ENTRY DETAIL Ribbon Garden Gate Slip Write one pretend sign of welcome at Ribbon Garden Gate: _____. A grown-up can ask who might step through next: _____.
QUIET STORY PASS VISUAL DETAIL Glow Shelf Lagoon Slip Add one glowing object above Glow Shelf Lagoon: _____. A grown-up can ask what the glow changes in the setting: _____.	FAMILY STORY PASS SETTING ACTION Blue Lantern Orchard Slip Write one gentle action happening in Blue Lantern Orchard: _____. A grown-up can ask how that action begins a story: _____.

Optional share prompts

- The pretend setting I picked for my story is _____.
- One invented clue that made it feel alive was _____.
- The color I added to the setting was _____.
- The sound on my paper slip was _____.
- The setting changed the character by making them feel _____.
- A made-up object that belongs there is _____.
- The next paper card could move the story toward _____.
- A family member can add one pretend detail here: _____.

Moon Muffin Market Glow Stall

Adult setup: Adult: set this paper tray card beside blank paper and ask for made-up moon-market details only: _____.

Turn the tray into a moon-muffin story place using one name, mood, edge, and object: _____.



Moon Muffin Market

Setting name
Setting name: invent a moon-market stall or aisle name that sounds made-up: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose how the stall feels when the moon lamps glow: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: draw or write what sits at one pretend border of the stall: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: replace one plain word with a moon-market detail that makes the setting clearer: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the short label that belongs on the paper tray card: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one imagined color, sound, scent, or texture: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one item that proves the story is in this stall: _____.

Quiet option: point to the tray label, then copy one setting word: _____. **Take-home line:** make one new paper tray setting from a pretend moon-market clue: _____.

Puddle Planet Ripple Mail Tray

Adult setup: Adult: offer one paper tray card and two invented ripple-mail labels, then let the writer choose: _____.

Make a puddle-planet mail setting from pretend stamps, ripples, and floating shelves: _____.



Puddle Planet Post Office

Setting name
Setting name: invent a name for the puddle mail counter or ripple-sorting spot: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the short tray label a helper would sort by: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose how the puddle mail spot feels: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one color, ripple sound, smooth texture, or pretend scent: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: show what borders the puddle mail spot, such as a pebble rail or leaf dock: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one paper mail object, such as a ripple stamp or shell tag: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: replace a plain puddle detail with a stronger planet-mail detail: _____.

Quiet option: point to one pretend stamp, then write one setting word: _____. **Take-home line:** invent another ripple-mail setting on a blank paper tray: _____.

Buttonwood Library Train Shelf Stop

Adult setup: Adult: set the paper tray card beside a ticket outline and keep every shelf-stop detail pretend: _____.

Choose where the train car pauses in the pretend buttonwood library: _____.



Buttonwood Library Train

Setting name
Setting name: invent a shelf-stop name for the Buttonwood Library Train: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the label that would sit on this paper shelf-stop tray: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose how the shelf stop feels when brass bells chime: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one lamp color, wheel sound, wood texture, or page scent: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: write what marks one border of the shelf stop: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one library-train object, such as a button ticket or lantern bookmark: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: add one moving-train or buttonwood detail to make the shelf stop less plain: _____.

Quiet option: name one anchor object, then add one setting word: _____. **Take-home line:** build another paper shelf-stop setting with one pretend ticket clue: _____.

Button Bakery Folded Map Corner

Adult setup: Adult: give the writer one paper tray card and say the bakery map is pretend, folded, and silly: _____.

Design the spot where the button map gets mixed up and then becomes clearer: _____.



Button Bakery Map Mix-Up

Setting name Setting name: invent a bakery-map spot name that belongs in a button story: _____.	Tray label Tray label: write the tray label for the folded paper map corner: _____.
Mood clue Mood clue: choose how the corner feels before the mix-up is solved: _____.	Sensory clue Sensory clue: add one color, crinkle sound, warm scent, or button texture: _____.
Map edge Map edge: write what sits at one map edge, such as a ribbon turn or button arch: _____.	Object anchor Object anchor: pick one object that fixes the setting in this paper corner: _____.
Revise setting Revise setting: add one button, fold, crumb, or map mark that makes the setting easier to picture: _____.	

Quiet option: point to one folded-map clue, then fill one setting word: _____. **Take-home line:** make one new bakery-map setting from a pretend paper fold: _____.

Teacup Town Weather Pane Plaza

Adult setup: Adult: set the paper tray card beside a drawn teacup outline and choose one pretend weather symbol together: _____.

Make the tiny weather-pane setting change mood without changing the whole story place: _____.



Teacup Town Weather Window

Setting name
Setting name: invent a name for the teacup view or weather pane: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the paper tray label for this weather pane setting: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose how the pane feels when the weather shifts: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one color, tiny sound, soft texture, or pretend breeze detail: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: write what borders the pane, such as a saucer rim or cloud ribbon: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one object that belongs near the pane: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: change one plain weather word into a teacup-town detail: _____.

Quiet option: choose one mood word and fill the blank: _____. **Take-home line:** create one more paper weather-pane setting with a tiny object clue: _____.

Pocket Park Ribbon Notice Nook

Adult setup: Adult: keep every notice invented, set one paper tray card beside a blank board shape, and pick a gentle park clue: _____.

Design the spot around the notice board using one label, one edge, and one object: _____.



Pocket Park Notice Board

Setting name Setting name: invent a pocket-park notice-board name that sounds make-believe: _____.	Tray label Tray label: write the short tray label for the notice-board setting: _____.
Mood clue Mood clue: choose how the pocket park feels when a ribbon notice flutters: _____.	Sensory clue Sensory clue: add one color, rustle sound, leaf texture, or paper mark: _____.
Map edge Map edge: write what sits at one edge of the notice nook: _____.	Object anchor Object anchor: pick one object that belongs by the notice board: _____.
Revise setting Revise setting: add one detail that makes the notice-board setting more pocket-park specific: _____.	

Quiet option: point to one pretend notice shape, then add one setting word: _____. **Take-home line:** invent another paper notice-board setting with one friendly clue: _____.

Lunchbox Harbor Spoon Ferry Markers

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in a paper tray and invite the writer to invent only pretend harbor details: _____.

List three paper harbor spots where the spoon ferry can pause, turn, or wait: _____.



Spoon Ferry Lunchbox Harbor

Setting name
Setting name: invent what the harbor is called: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write a short label that tells what kind of make-believe harbor this is: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose the harbor feeling, such as busy, sleepy, sparkly, or fog-soft: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add two imagined details near the tray piers: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: mark one border of the paper map where the pretend water continues beyond the tray: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one object such as a tiny spoon flag, button buoy, or folded paper crate: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: change one edge, pause spot, or object so the story has more setting detail: _____.

Quiet option: circle one detail and add only one new word beside it: _____. **Take-home line:** use the harbor again as the opening setting for a new pretend ferry tale: _____.

Acorn Avenue Errand Sorting Grove

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in a paper tray and frame the errand hub as made-up from start to finish: _____.

Decide which acorn helpers visit the hub and what each corner is used for in the story: _____.



Acorn Avenue Errand Office

Setting name

Setting name: invent what this acorn errand hub is called: _____.

Tray label

Tray label: write a tray label that tells what gets sorted here using only story details: _____.

Mood clue

Mood clue: choose the errand hub feeling, such as brisk, careful, cheerful, or quietly curious: _____.

Sensory clue

Sensory clue: add two pretend senses from paper crates, leaf stamps, pebble bells, or twig signs: _____.

Map edge

Map edge: mark one paper border where the next make-believe errand waits off the tray: _____.

Object anchor

Object anchor: choose one anchor object, such as a walnut tag, feather clip, or folded leaf slip: _____.

Revise setting

Revise setting: change one corner so the errand feels easier, stranger, or funnier: _____.

Quiet option: add one small symbol instead of a long sentence: _____. **Take-home line:** reuse the hub as a starting spot for a new errand tale: _____.

Seed Library Map Archive Legend

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in a paper tray and remind the writer that all seed labels, symbols, and map marks are invented: _____.

Create a map legend with three seed symbols and decide what each symbol changes in the setting: _____.



Seed Library Map Room

Setting name Setting name: invent what this seed archive is called: _____.	Tray label Tray label: write a tray label that explains the archive purpose: _____.
Mood clue Mood clue: choose the archive feeling, such as hushed, curious, glowing, or puzzle-bright: _____.	Sensory clue Sensory clue: add two imagined sensations from dry paper husks, smooth seed beads, or whispery folders: _____.
Map edge Map edge: mark what appears beyond one paper map edge using only invented landmarks: _____.	Object anchor Object anchor: pick one object that proves this setting belongs to a story: _____.
Revise setting Revise setting: add one rule for how maps are shelved, folded, or traded: _____.	

Quiet option: draw a single symbol for the setting mood: _____. **Take-home line:** use one seed symbol to open the next fictional setting: _____.

Rain Gauge Railway Weather Bend

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in a paper tray and keep every rail, gauge, and sign fully invented on paper: _____.

Choose where the railway pauses when the rain gauge fills, empties, or tilts: _____.



Rain Gauge Railway

Setting name
Setting name: invent what this rainy railway is called: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write a tray label for the railway bend, platform, or crossing: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose the weather mood, such as silver, jumpy, calm, or gentle thunder-rumbly: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add two imagined sensations, such as rain taps, cool rail shine, or soft puddle hush: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: mark one paper edge where the railway disappears into mist, reeds, or clouds: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one anchor object, such as a tilted gauge, brass bell, or blue ticket stub: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: change how the gauge affects the next scene: _____.

Quiet option: draw the gauge level and one nearby setting clue: _____. **Take-home line:** bring the gauge clue into another pretend railway tale: _____.

Moss Message Observatory Signal Shelf

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in a paper tray and state that every moss signal, sky mark, and lookout note is pretend: _____.

Decide what the moss signals show about the observatory weather, sound, and borders: _____.



Moss Message Observatory

Setting name
Setting name: invent what this moss observatory is called: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write a tray label that explains the observatory signal job: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose the observatory feeling, such as patient, moonlit, breezy, or lantern-warm: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add two imagined sensations, such as springy moss, cool stone, or whispery wind: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: mark what sits beyond one paper border: cloud steps, fern towers, or glow fog: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: pick one object such as a moss dial, folded sky chart, or pebble lens: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: change what one moss signal means for the setting: _____.

Quiet option: add one moss mark and one sky mark only: _____. **Take-home line:** reuse the moss signal as the first clue in a new fictional setting: _____.

Tidepool Clock-Shelf Lab Setting

Adult setup: Adult: set this card in the paper tray and name the tidepool lab as a pretend story world: _____.

Create a tidepool lab setting where a tiny change in the water marks tells the story what is happening next: _____.



Tidepool Timekeepers Lab

Setting name
Setting name: name the invented tidepool lab area where the story begins: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the short label that would sit on this card in the paper tray: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose calm, busy, puzzled, or bright, then add one reason the tidepool lab feels that way: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one color, texture, or soft sound from the tidepool setting: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: draw or name what appears at the far edge of the pretend tidepool map: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one invented paper object that proves the setting is a timekeepers lab: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: replace one plain detail with a sharper tide, shell, clock, or chart detail: _____.

Quiet option: sketch one tide mark and write only its setting clue: _____. **Take-home line:** save this card and add one new tidepool lab detail on another paper slip: _____.

Revision River Ferry Clear-View Setting

Adult setup: Adult: put the card in the paper tray, then invite the writer to keep the ferry world invented: _____.

Build the ferry setting so the crossing changes from unclear to vivid by the end of the paragraph: _____.



Revision River Ferry

Setting name
Setting name: name the invented ferry deck, dock, river bend, or page pier: _____.

Tray label
Tray label: write the short ferry-setting label for this tray card: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: show how the ferry feels before and after the setting becomes clearer: _____.

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one ripple sound, mist color, rope texture, or paper creak: _____.

Map edge
Map edge: mark what waits at the far river edge of the pretend map: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one invented ferry object that helps the setting feel specific: _____.

Revise setting
Revise setting: change one vague ferry detail into a concrete dock, ripple, rope, or lantern detail: _____.

Quiet option: write only the unclear detail and the clearer detail: _____. **Take-home line:** save this card and add a new ferry setting clue on a folded paper slip: _____.

Clue Label Tower Exhibit-Tier Setting

Adult setup: Adult: put this card in the paper tray and remind the writer that every exhibit clue is pretend: _____.

Invent a tower museum setting where one label makes the reader notice the right clue: _____.



Clue Label Tower Museum

Setting name
Setting name: name the invented tower tier, exhibit nook, label arch, or clue balcony:

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose curious, grand, quiet, or cluttered, then explain what creates that mood:

Map edge
Map edge: mark which label hangs at the edge of the pretend tower map: _____

Revise setting
Revise setting: swap one plain label word for a specific shape, material, or motion clue:

Tray label
Tray label: write the short label that identifies this museum setting card: _____

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one color, shape, surface, or hush-sound from the tower museum:

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one invented display tag, label stand, or paper magnifier for the setting:

Quiet option: sketch one label box and write only its strongest setting clue: _____. **Take-home line:** save this card and add another invented exhibit label on paper: _____.

Compass Craft Choice-Point Setting

Adult setup: Adult: put this card in the paper tray and keep every craft detail pretend and drawn: _____.

Design a compass craft setting where the materials and marks show which choice matters most: _____.



Compass Craft Academy

Setting name
Setting name: name the invented needle hall, bead arch, compass court, or craft rail:

Tray label
Tray label: write the short paper tray label for this compass setting: _____.

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose steady, curious, tangled, or bright, then add the setting clue that proves it:

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one line color, bead texture, paper fold, or gentle tapping sound:

Map edge
Map edge: mark what lies beyond the last compass point on the pretend map: _____.

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one invented paper needle, bead card, folded arrow, or craft tag:

Revise setting
Revise setting: replace one broad direction word with a specific setting clue the reader can picture:

Quiet option: mark one compass point and write only its setting clue: _____, **Take-home line:** save this card and add one new compass craft material on paper: _____.

Binding Day Boardwalk Final-Page Setting

Adult setup: Adult: put this card in the paper tray and frame the boardwalk as an invented paper story world: _____.

Build a boardwalk setting where loose page pieces show what the ending needs: _____.



Binding Day Boardwalk

Setting name
Setting name: name the invented page booth, stitch gate, binding rail, or boardwalk bend:

Tray label
Tray label: write the short label that fits this final-page setting card: _____

Mood clue
Mood clue: choose settled, busy, hopeful, or tidy, then add one boardwalk clue that creates the feeling:

Sensory clue
Sensory clue: add one paper-flutter sound, wood-grain texture, thread color, or salt-air hint:

Map edge
Map edge: mark what sits at the far edge of the boardwalk map after the final page:

Object anchor
Object anchor: choose one invented button tag, thread loop, page clasp, or folded sign:

Revise setting
Revise setting: move one setting detail earlier so the ending feels connected: _____

Quiet option: number two setting details and write only the final one: _____. **Take-home line:** save this card and add one boardwalk detail that could close the story: _____.